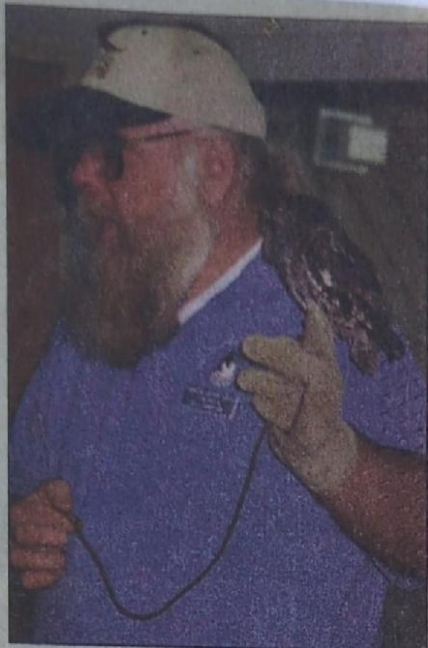


Students adopt falcon, two small owls following trip to Raptor Center



Above, fourth-graders from Waxhaw Elementary ride a school bus to the Carolina Raptor Center during a field trip in October. Following the trip, the students learned how to adopt birds at the center and raised the money to do so. At right, a rescued eagle sits perched on a branch at the Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville, just north of Charlotte.





Carolina Raptor Center guide and educator Tom Rouse shows an owl to a group of Waxhaw fourth-graders during the "Predators of the Sky" program at the center.

Fourth-graders adopt raptors after field day

By Nick Roskelly
Union West Writer

Waxhaw

Fourth-graders from Waxhaw Elementary recently donated \$250 to the Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville after taking a field-trip to the center in the fall.

The 83 students raised 1,000 quarters in math class, while studying the definition of a millennium. When their lesson was complete, the students and teachers decided to give the money to the raptor center.

"The students have been studying groups of animals since the beginning of the school year," teacher Marsha Strawn said.

"And they really enjoyed going to the raptor center."

With the money, the students adopted a falcon and two small owls and purchased a brick with the inscription "Fourth Graders, Waxhaw Elementary, 1999-2000," to be placed in a walkway at the center.

The raptor center will send adoption papers and photographs of the falcon and two owls to the school for the students to keep in the classrooms.

"The money from the Waxhaw Elementary students will go toward feed, health care and will help all the birds at the center," said Rhonda Belk, raptor center education assistant.

The students studied the "Predators from the Sky" program for two hours at the raptor center. Raptor center program guide and educator Tom Rouse said that the students were attentive and interested during their tour.

"Predators from the Sky," one of the 10 or so programs at the center, is a basic introduction to raptors.

"The program explains the mission at the center, introduces a few birds, talks about their importance and protection."

The raptors, or birds-of-prey, at the center include eagles, falcons, hawks, owls, vultures and ospreys. The center treats injured and orphaned birds from across the Carolinas. After caring for the birds, the center returns them to a natural habitat. In some cases, however, the birds recover with disabilities and become permanent residents at the center and are used for educational programs.

"It's great for the student to learn why the birds can't go back into the wild and how (the students) can help the raptor population as a whole," Strawn said.

New programs in accordance with the North Carolina Science Curriculum were added this year in addition to the raptor center's four original programs, "Predators from the Sky," "Owls, Owls Fantastical Fowls," "Raptors in Native American Culture" and "Amazing Adaptations."

The raptor center started in a basement at UNC-Charlotte in 1979 and became an incorporated company in 1981. In 1984 the center moved to its present location at Latta Plantation in Huntersville.

To get to the Carolina Raptor Center, take U.S. 77 north to exit 16B and follow the signs. For more information about visiting the center, call (704) 875-6521.